

Project leaders as boundary spanners: Relational antecedents and performance outcomes

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Abstract

Research has shown that NPD project leaders should engage in boundary-spanning activities. The present study tested the impact of four boundary-spanning activities on NPD project performance and analyzed the antecedents of these activities. We hypothesized that NPD project leaders' abilities to perform these activities depend on the characteristics of their personal networks — structural holes, strength of ties, vertical and horizontal bridging ties. A Partial Least Squares test on 73 NPD projects showed that (a) “obtaining political support” and “scanning for ideas” are the boundary activities with the greatest impact on performance, (b) project leaders with strong ties in their network are more effective at these activities, (c) project leaders with structural holes in their networks are more effective in another boundary activity, “protecting the team”, although this activity does not affect NPD outcomes. These results represent an important contribution to understanding how team leaders contribute to project performance.

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1. Introduction

The specific contribution of team leaders to the performance of NPD projects has been widely studied in the project management literature (Aronson et al., 2008; Sarin and O'Connor, 2009). Due to their pivotal role in coordination, planning, conflict solving, and many other important aspects of project management, project leaders' professional qualifications and leadership style make a difference (Odusami et al., 2003). Beyond these team-oriented leadership roles, project leaders also bring value through their ability to manage key relationships outside the team. Indeed, project performance is highly dependent on access to external technical inputs, coordination with important stakeholders, and support from top management and other players who influence the project without belonging to the project team (Ancona and Caldwell, 1992; Choi, 2002).

Tushman and Katz (1980) referred to this aspect of the project leader's role as “boundary spanning”. Recent research into team management has revived this notion (Faraj and Yan, 2009; Joshi et al., 2009; Marrone, 2010; Marrone et al., 2007; Ratcheva, 2009), and clarified the overall impact of boundary spanning on team performance. Nevertheless, some questions of particular importance for NPD project management remain unanswered. For instance, what types of boundary-spanning activities have the greatest impact on project performance and do they all bring value? To date, research has concentrated either on one type of boundary spanning activity, for example, searching for external knowledge (Ratcheva, 2009), or considered boundary spanning as a single activity with no distinction between different types of activity. Our research was designed to try and fill this gap by developing the notion that not all boundary-spanning activities are beneficial. For example, focusing on relations with external players may consume a lot

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